professor in the Faculty of Planning at CEPT University. The survey substantiates this. Some 28 per cent of people across the country walk to their workplaces, and the figure in cities is not as low as one might expect—a solid 13.5 per cent. People walking a kilometre or more to work are people trying to save money, says Joshi. Think a domestic worker who walks to several homes in a day but does not take a better-paid factory job far away, and so she stays poorer.

Gaps in Infrastructure

But part of the equation is the lack of safe, reliable public transport. Nearly 22 per cent of urban women workers use the bus as their main mode of transport. A sobering paradox comes out in studies cited by Karthick: even though 80 to 85 per cent of urban women rely on public transport or walking, only 20 per cent actually feel safe on a bus or metro.

Government priorities work like a zero sum game. Spending on women's safety is vital, but not at the cost of upkeep of transport facilities—that ends up discouraging travel anyway. "Gender isn't mainstreamed in government planning," says Karthick. "A man typically goes from home to office and back. A woman may have to drop children at school, run an errand, then go to work. Our transport system isn't designed for that," he says. When Vienna found that women tend to make multiple stops, he says, the city factored that in while

THE SHORTCOMINGS

- Women's travel needs stay unmet without upkeep of facilities, safe public spaces
- Policy focuses on cars, the main mode of transport for just 3% of workers nationally
- Inadequate focus on last-mile connectivity and infrastructure for walkers, cyclists

THE SOLUTIONS

- Expand bus fleets, routes and evening services so women can reach jobs safely
- Build continuous footpaths at least two metres wide; curb encroachment
- Budget for upkeep, not just construction; lights, stops fail without maintenance



"Women rely on walking and public buses much more. People walking a kilometre or more to work are trying to save money. Think of a domestic worker walking to several homes a day and not taking a better-paying factory job as it's far away. She stays poorer"

— **RUTUL JOSHI,** *Faculty, Urban Planning, CEPT Ahmedabad*

HOW INDIA MOVES
DOMESTIC TRAVEL

THE SURGE IN LEISURE TRIPS

Domestic travel is booming, trips have almost doubled over the past decade, and it's working young people who are heading out more

By **SONAL KHETARPAL**

